



TIPS & TRICKS

Useful `ls` command options

Here are two options for the `ls` command that can be very useful while using the Linux shell prompt.

```
ls -ltrh
```

The command given above will show the file size as human readable format.

```
ls -ltrR
```

This command will show all the files under all sub-directories.

—Murali Selvaraj,
murali.selvaraj2003@gmail.com

Speed up your USB modem

Configuring a GSM-based USB modem on a Linux operating system is a long procedure for those using an older kernel. There are several tutorials available on the Internet that can help you configure the modem, one of which I used to configure my MTS modem and it worked fine. But after using it for a while, I felt that it was a bit slower than what I had experienced on the Windows-based computer.

Here is a simple tip that can help anyone facing the same issue. You can speed up your download speed by simply changing the baud rate. I have used `wvdial` to configure the modem. To change the baud rate, follow the steps given below. Do remember to execute all commands as the root.

Open the configuration file in any text editor, as follows:

```
#vi /etc/wvdial.conf
```

...and change the value of the field 'baud', i.e., instead of 9600 you can use 57600 (it works fine for an MTS USB modem).

Now try connecting to the Internet using your USB modem to experience higher speeds.

—Chekkizhar,
chekkizhar@yahoo@gmail.com

Log in without a password

Have you ever tried to log in to the GUI desktop without a password in GNU/Linux? If not, then you can try the following tip. Though it is not recommended to log in to any user without a password, yet if there is a need, you can do so by following the steps given below.

Open the `shadow` file in any text editor as the root user.

```
#vi /etc/shadow
```

Then search for the line that your preferred user exists in and remove the encrypted phrase that comes after the username (the phrase is between colons).

For example, the original line in `shadow` file for user `guest` is as shown below:

```
guest:$2a$05$3oi16opU.FK59hEqZy0W67 MELn4VLCrTnT5e4i  
bVM7a5G:15294:0:99999:7::
```

After the change, it should look like what follows:

```
guest::15294:0:99999:7::
```

Now, the user will be able to log in, even graphically, without a password.

—Bejoy Abraham Mathews,
bejnet@yahoo.com

Hide your command in the terminal

This is a simple trick that will hide whatever you type on the terminal window.

To hide the typed command in the terminal, just type the following command and press `Enter`:

```
#stty -echo
```

To enable the display of the typed command in the terminal, enter the command given below: